

JAMES WILD & CO.

COSTA RICA

THE QUICK GUIDE, IN FOUR PAGES

When to go, where your kind of trip lives, ten places not to miss and who you'll meet in the trees. Read it over one coffee.

COVER: RED-EYED TREE FROG
GETTY IMAGES



HI, I'M IGGI · JAMES'S TRIP-BUILDING BUDDY

Circle what makes you grin, then find **Iggi's Compass** on the Costa Rica page at jameswildco.com. Tell me your month and your crew; the trip takes shape before your coffee's cold. *Never lost. Only scenic.*

01 · WHEN TO GO — PLAN

Where to be, month by month

December to April is dry and sunny on the Pacific side. May to November is the green season: afternoon rain, roaring waterfalls, turtles, whales and fewer people.

January
MONTEVERDE

Quetzal season begins. The bird is real; your guide knows which tree.

February
CARIBBEAN COAST

The Caribbean side dries out. Reef, reggae and nobody on the beach.

March
GUANACASTE

The sunniest month in the northwest. Pack sunscreen like you mean it.

April
ARENAL

Last of the dry season. Easter week is busy: book early or go late.

May
PACUARE

First rains, first green. The forest exhales.

June
PACUARE RIVER

The rivers rise and the rafting gets lively. Hold on.

July
PACIFIC COAST

The "little summer" on the Pacific, and green turtles begin nesting.

August
UVITA

Humpbacks offshore in the morning, waterfalls in the afternoon.

September
CARIBBEAN COAST

The Pacific gets soaked; the Caribbean smiles. Go east.

October
TORTUGUERO

Turtle hatchlings sprint for the sea. The quietest month, and the best-kept secret.

November
OSA PENINSULA

Shoulder season: fewer people, fair weather, good rates.

December
EVERYWHERE

Dry season returns, and so does everyone. We booked your room in June.

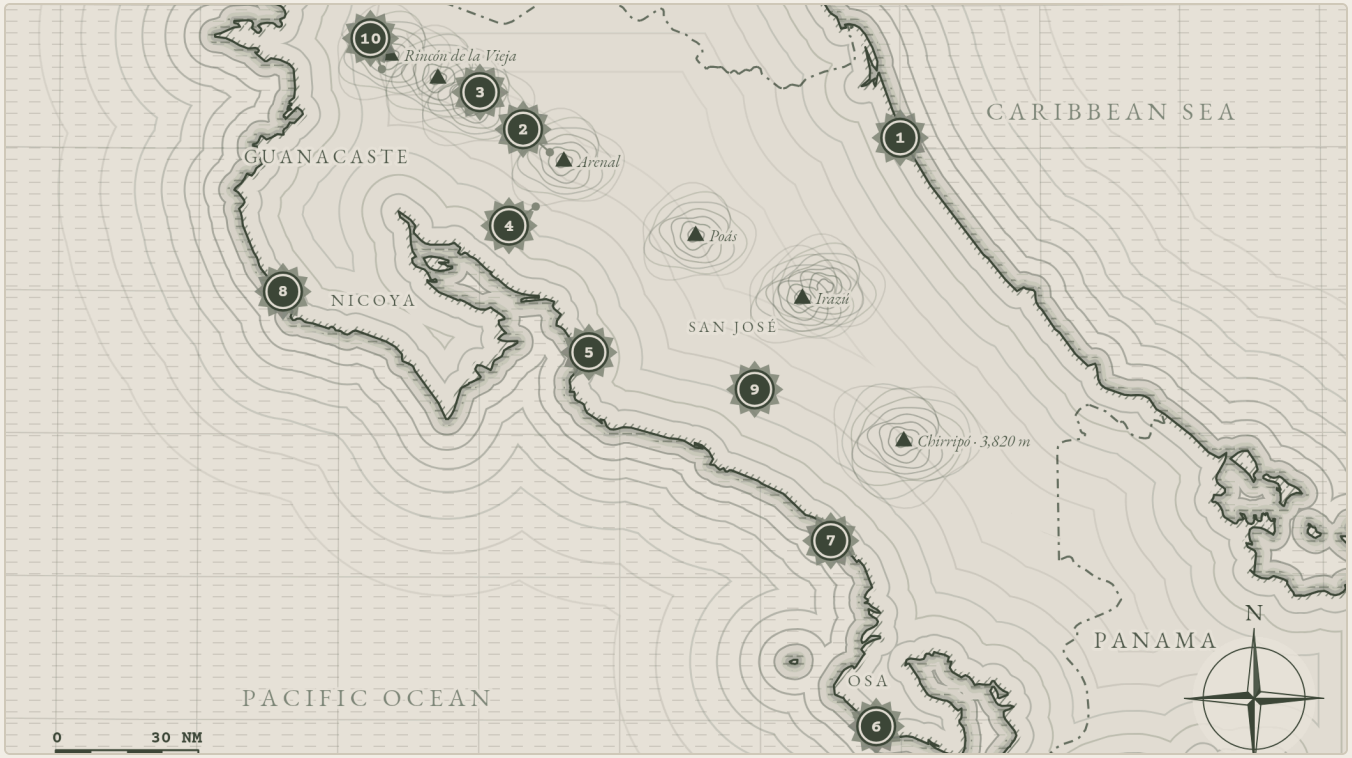
02 · WHO IT'S FOR — PLAN

IF YOU'RE…	GO	WHERE	OUR PICK
First-timers	Dec–Apr	Arenal · Monteverde · Guanacaste	Two Oceans, One Volcano
Families, young kids	Dec–Apr · July	Arenal · Papagayo	Four Seasons Papagayo
Teens & three generations	Jun–Aug · Dec	Pacuare · Arenal · the Osa	Pacuare Lodge
Honeymooners	Dec–Apr	Rincón de la Vieja · the Osa	Origins Lodge
Wildlife lovers & birders	Dec–Apr birds · Jul–Oct turtles & whales	The Osa · Tortuguero · Monteverde	Lapa Rios
Wellness seekers	May–Nov	Nosara · Arenal	Nayara Springs · Harmony

Ten places, one map

The ones I'd send my own family to. Numbers match the map; circle yours and tell Iggi.

JAMES SAYS DON'T MISS THIS ONE



1. **Tortuguero canals** — CARIBBEAN COAST
   No roads, all canals. Turtles nest July to October; caimans work the day shift.

2. **Arenal's hot river** — LA FORTUNA
   A volcano-warmed river where the locals soak for free. Nature's jacuzzi, no booking required.

3. **Río Celeste** — TENORIO VOLCANO NATIONAL PARK
   Where two rivers meet and turn sky-blue. It looks retouched. It isn't.

4. **Monteverde hanging bridges** — CLOUD FOREST
   Walk the canopy at cloud level. Go early; the quetzals don't do crowds.

5. **Tárcoles River bridge** — CENTRAL PACIFIC
   Dozens of crocodiles posing below. The best free photo op that can also eat you.

6. **Corcovado, Sirena station** — THE OSA PENINSULA
   The wildest walk in Central America. Tapirs, macaws and mud to the knee.

7. **The whale's tail** — MARINO BALLENA, UVITA
   At low tide the sandbar draws a whale's tail. The real ones swim past in season.

8. **Ostional arribadas** — NICOYA PENINSULA
   On arribada nights, thousands of olive ridley turtles come ashore together. Nature's flash mob.

9. **Tarrazú coffee farms** — LOS SANTOS HIGHLANDS
   The best cup of your life, poured by the person who picked it.

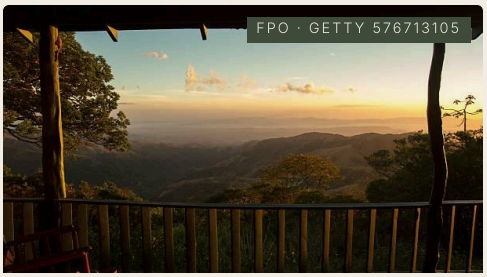
10. **Rincón de la Vieja** — GUANACASTE
    Bubbling mud pots and steaming vents. The volcano smells faintly of breakfast eggs.

The rest, in short

LOOK FOR	WHERE	BEST
Sloths, two- and three-toed	everywhere with trees	all year
Scarlet macaws	the Osa · Carara	all year
Resplendent quetzal	Monteverde · San Gerardo de Dota	Dec–Apr [confirm]
Red-eyed tree frog	lowland rainforest, at night	all year
Humpback whales	Marino Ballena · Uvita · the Osa	Jul–Oct · Dec–Mar
Sea turtles	Tortuguero · Ostional	Jul–Oct

GIVE SPACE TO

- **Fer-de-lance:** stay on the trail, closed shoes, a guide after dark.
- **Capuchins:** they steal lunches. Zip everything.
- **Crocodiles and rip currents:** no swimming in river mouths.



Sundowners in Monteverde GETTY IMAGES

SEVEN STAYS WE'D BOOK

1. Nayara Springs · ARENAL
2. Lapa Rios Lodge · OSA PENINSULA
3. Pacuare Lodge · PACUARE RIVER
4. Origins Lodge · RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA
5. Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo · GUANACASTE
6. Hacienda AltaGracia · PÉREZ ZELEDÓN
7. Harmony Hotel Nosara · NOSARA

FIVE RULES OF THE ROAD

Fly the far ones · Never drive after dark · Two nights minimum anywhere you fly to · The side with the "Ceda el paso" sign waits · Book December to April early

JAMES WILD & CO. I KEEP GOING BACK COSTA RICA · SINCE 1991

JAMES WILD & CO. LEDGERED & VETTED JOURNEY DESIGN SINCE 1982

READY? FOLLOW MY TAIL

Tell Iggi your month.
James takes it from there.

Tap Iggi's Compass at jameswildco.com/costa-rica?src=quick03, or text James on 561.479.6355. Want the long version? Ask for the 24-page field guide.

Already have a travel advisor? We're happy to work with them. Facts checked October 2026; seasons are guidance only. Photographs: Getty Images, all of Costa Rica; FPO = layout comp awaiting licence. Map from Natural Earth data. FL Seller of Travel ST45327 · IATAN 10783883 · Exploring Since 1982. © 2026 James Wild & Co.